

day Turkey, archaeologists have spent years sifting through the remains of hundreds of houses, built about 9,000 years ago. Analysis has shown that women and men had similar diets, and spent a similar amount of time indoors. After death, men and women's bodies were also buried in much the same way, so there is little evidence to suggest a significant division between men and women in terms of the tasks or roles they performed.

As the centuries passed, the hunter-gatherer lifestyle gradually gave way to a more settled existence. People began to occupy dwellings close to food and water sources, and grow crops instead of gathering wild plants. This change, called the Neolithic Revolution, had wide-reaching effects. For example, the rise of agriculture led to an increased reliance on grains as a dietary staple. Kernels were ground into flour to make them easier to eat, a process that required hard labor. Studies of female bones from the period, compared to those of modern students (some of them athletes) shows that many Neolithic women had stronger arms than the average contemporary woman, which could be the result of many hours spent grinding grain.

Historic women

The prehistoric period is characterized by its lack of written records. Early forms of writing began to be used in many cultures during what is called the Bronze Age. Writing emerged in Greece during the Aegean Bronze



Age (c. 3000–1000 BCE), but archaeologists have only managed to decipher one of the society's three scripts. If the Minoans wrote anything about women, scholars are yet to be able to read it. As in the prehistoric period, clues as to how women lived during this time are mostly found in art, artefacts, and burial sites. Minoan and Mycenaean women, for example, were frequently depicted in frescos engaged in a variety of activities—but notably pregnancy and childbirth are rarely shown. In Minoan Greece, women were painted seated on thrones more frequently than men, leading some scholars to infer that Minoan civilization was matriarchal.

▲ Gold diadem

Archaeologists previously used grave goods, like this gold, elliptical diadem from the "Grave of the Women" in Mycenae, to assume the gender of burials, but this method is now disputed (see pp. 204–205).

"IT WASN'T JUST A BUNCH OF GUYS OUT THERE CHASING BISON AROUND."

DEAN SNOW, ARCHAEOLOGIST AND EXPERT ON CAVE ART